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LETTER OF COLUMBUS,

TO

LUIS DE SANTANGEL,

1493.

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Fac-similes of the Spanish Letter of Columbus

Published in 1493,

From the only known copy in the Ambrosian Library, Milan.

Commencement

Señor por que se que aureis plazer dela grand victoria que uro señor me ha dado en mi voy aie vos escrivo esta por la ql sabreys como en xxxvj dias pase alas yndias cola armada que los illustrissimos Rey y reyna uros señores me dieron donde yo halle muy muchas Islas pobladas con gente sin numero. y dellas todas he tomado posesscio por sus altezas con pregon y vandera real estendida y no me fue contradicho:

Close of the Letter.

ala espana mas a todos los christianos ternan aqui refrigerio p ganancia esto segm el fecho asi en breue fecha en la carauela sobre las yslas de canaria a xv. de febrero. Mill.y quatrocientos y nouenta y tres años.

Para lo que mandareys El almirante,

Syma que yenia dentro en la carta.

Despues desta escripto: y estando en mar de Castilla salyo tanto viento comigo. tul y sneste que me ha fecho descargar los namos por cort aqui en este pnerto de lysbona op q fue la mayor maranilla del mundo adonde acorde escrinir alas altezas. En todas las yndias he siempre hallado los temporales como en mayo adonde yo fuy en xxxvij. dias zbolui en xxxiij. falvo questas tormentas me han detenido. xxxij. dias corrieudo por estamar. Dizen aqua todos los hombres dela mar que jamas ono tan mal yuierno no mi tatas perdidas de names, fecha a. xxxij. dias de maco.

Esta carta embio Colon a lescrivano Deracion delas Islas halladas en las Yndias, Contenida a otra Desus Altezas.

LETTER OF COLUMBUS,

TO

LUIS DE SANTANGEL,

1493.

By James Lenox
Signed L. at end

36
Columbus

New York,
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LETTER OF COLUMBUS,
1493.

A PRINTED copy of the firſt letter of Columbus *in Spaniſh*, addreſſed to Luis de Santangel,[1] has at length been diſcovered in the Ambroſian Library at Milan. It belongs to a collection of books and manuſcripts bequeathed to

[1] He is called at the cloſe of the letter Eſcribano de Racion. This office ſeems from Navarrete's explanation to include thoſe of Secretary and Steward of the Royal Houſehold.

that library about twelve years ago by the Baron Pietro Cuſtodi, a Milaneſe hiſtorian and political economiſt. It is a ſmall quarto of four leaves in ſemi-gothic type---that is with black letter and roman characters mixed:--- the text begins on the recto of the firſt leaf without any title, and fills ſeven entire pages, and above a third of the eighth page. The full page contains 32 lines, while there are only eleven lines of text on the 8th page, followed by a poſtcript of 14 lines.[1] The firſt

[1] This Spaniſh original muſt not be confounded with the other letter written by Columbus at the ſame time to Rafael Sanchez, the royal Treaſurer, tranſlated from the Spaniſh into Latin by Leander de

capital letter, S, is an ornamented wood cut, occupying the ſquare ſpace of 5 lines of the text. There are neither ſignatures, catchwords, pagination, nor paragraphs---the text being printed without any break in the lines. The paper is thick, and very much ſized---the water-mark is an open hand with the monogram of Chriſt over the third finger. The copy is in very good condition, with broad margins---a drop of oil, however, disfigures the laſt page. The whole leaf meaſures 20 centime-

Coſco. This tranſlation has been frequently printed. The two letters are in ſubſtance the ſame; but no cotemporaneouſly printed copy of that to Santangel was known until the diſcovery of the one now announced.

tres high by 14 broad, and the printed portion is 13.3 centimetres high by 16 broad.

Beſides this full account of this precious little book, my correſpondent has ſent me a fac ſimile of eight lines at the beginning, and five lines at the end of the letter, and of the whole 14 lines of the *Anyma* at the cloſe. A copy of this fac ſimile is given with this notice. Theſe portions agree generally with the reprint of Navarrete (vol. I, pages 167 to 175) from the MS. in the Royal Archives at Simancas. There are ſome variations, the moſt remarkable of which is his omiſſion of the words at the end of the letter.

" Faro lo que mandereys---El almirante." He has corrected the orthography in ſome places, and leaves out many of the contractions. Some of the readings of the letter are better than his, becauſe the words it ſupplies render the meaning more clear. The date at the cloſe is at the Canary Iſlands the 15th of February, 1493; and that of the Anyma the 14th day of March. Of the firſt Navarrete ſays, that the iſlands ſeen on the 15th February were the Azores, not the Canaries; and of the ſecond, that although the figures ſeem to indicate the 14th, the true date muſt be the 4th of March. *Anima*, he ſays, means a written paper, in-

ſerted in a letter after the letter is cloſed.

As there is no place or name of printer, theſe muſt remain unknown unleſs the type and watermark ſhould help ſome bibliophile to make a fortunate conjecture on theſe points. The volume, however, muſt have been printed before any of the Latin editions of the letter to Sanchez, and moſt probably in Spain.

I may refer in this place to the ſmall 8vo edition in Latin with wood cuts; which ſome bibliographers ſuppoſe to have been printed at Grenada, becauſe the arms and name of that city are found on the laſt page. Mr.

Brunet infers that this is not to be taken as poſitive proof that the book appeared at Grenada, and I am not diſpoſed to aſſert that he is miſtaken. But in other inſtances a ſimilar mark is conſidered an indication of the place of printing:---among theſe I may cite the German abridged edition of Columbus' Voyages, printed by Sigiſmund Grimm in 1522. The pine-apple on the laſt page is deemed good evidence that the volume was iſſued by him at Augſburg. (Vide Appendix B in the New York reprint of Syllacius, page lviii.) And I may add that the arms of Grenada *in the form*

in which they appear in the 8vo edition with wood cuts, are not found in any other edition. Even the Baſle edition of 1494, which copies all the other wood cuts of the little 8vo, *does not copy* theſe arms---but gives on the recto of the laſt leaf, the arms of Caſtile and Leon as theſe appear on the firſt leaf of the 8vo, and on the verſo of the ſame leaf reproduces the cut of the veſſel, found on the firſt leaf, both of the 8vo, and of its own firſt leaf, with the addition of an ornament above and below the cut. Theſe different wood cuts may be ſeen on pages xxxvi, xxxvii and xlii of Appendix 3 of the New York Syllacius.

In order to avoid miſapprehenſion I may add that in the portraits of Ferdinand both in the 8vo and in the Baſle editions, two eſcutcheons containing the arms of Caſtile, &c., and of Grenada hang from the arm of the king; but they have nothing to do with the crowned eſcutcheon, and the word Grenada as theſe are found on the laſt page of the little octavo.

I regret to ſay on the authority of my correſpondent that the copy of this laſt edition, deſcribed by Roſſi, has *diſappeared* from the Brera library in Milan. I will tranſcribe what he writes upon the ſubject. "Cette bibliothèque

vient de perdre l'exemplaire de la lettre de 1493, ſur laquelle Boſſi a fait ſes travaux. Ce vol a été fait avec une audace, et avec une adreſſe d'eſcarmoteur. Elle exiſtait encore à la bibliothèque il y a ſix ans. Nous avons ici des amateurs larrons dont on ne ſe garde pas aſſez, et qui ſont la peſte des collections *publiques* et *particuliéres ;* il y en a partout, mais chez nous ſe donnent rendezvous les filous du monde entier. Quant à la Bibliothèque Ambroſienne, c'eſt différent ; on y eſt moins confiant.

L.



